Managing Difficult Conversations

A Blueprint for Trust, Empathy, and Constructive Feedback

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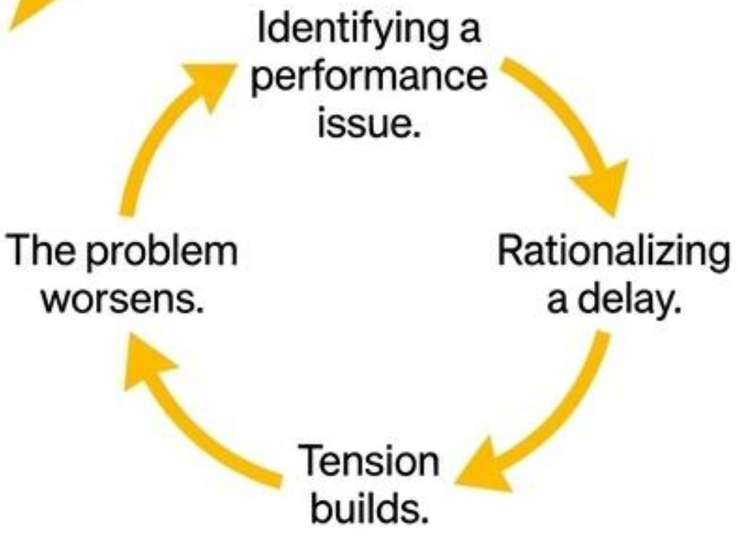
The Unspoken Conversations

A conversation I'm not having is...



What is the conversation about, with whom, and why are you repeatedly delaying it?

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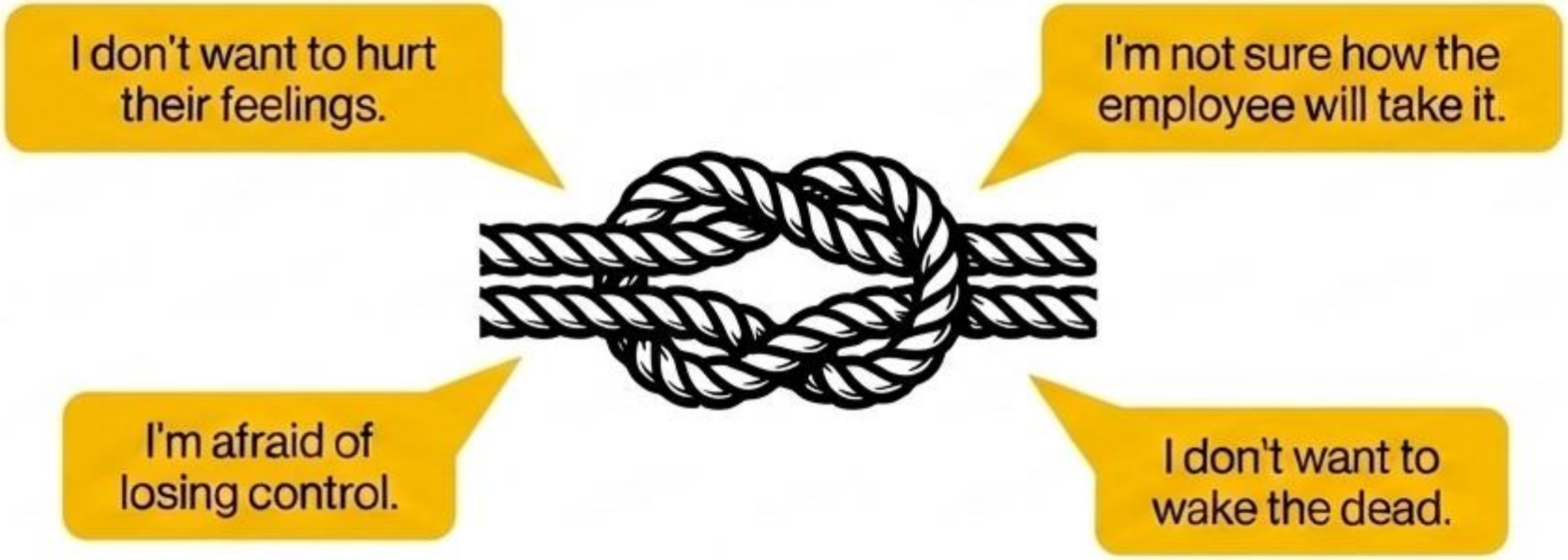
The Root Cause: Conflict Avoidance

We avoid difficult conversations because our default setting is to protect ourselves.



Core Insight: These fears stem from viewing conflict as a win-lose power struggle defined by negative emotions.

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Biology at Work

The Lions of Modern Life

Fight	Flight	Freeze
Office	**Office**	**Office**
Contain: stratn, and noanagement	Contain: strate, and naanagement	Contain: strate, and noanagement
Indicat fanw with measagement	Indicat liner with measagement	Indicat asaw with measagement
Biological: Attack the Lion	**Biological:** Run from the Lion	**Biological:** Play dead

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Reframing the Friction

> "When there is no conflict, something has died in the relationship."

- Conflict is an opportunity to grow.
- It is a chance to increase understanding.
- It is a method to achieve the shared task, goal, or mission.

Core Shift: It is not about eliminating conflict, but about managing it constructively. (Source: Dr Ichak Adizes)

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The Crossroads Matrix

Destructive Conflict

- Defined by win-lose dynamics.
- Intense negative emotions.
- Power struggles.
- Focuses on personalities.

1. Mutual Trust
2. Mutual Respect

Constructive Conflict

- Defined by mutual understanding.
- Catalyst for growth.
- Achieving the mission.
- Focuses on performance.

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The Psychology of ‘Being Seen’

Austrian psychologist Heinz Kohut defined defined two conditions an employee needs to develop personally and professionally.

Condition 1: Mirroring Positive Qualities	Condition 2: Visibility
The manager must **articulate what they appreciate.** This gives the employee a sense of worth and contributes to self-esteem.	**Too often, employees feel invisible or transparent.** A major goal of feedback is providing the sensation that their specific contribution is valued.

A lack of value or appreciation results in alienation.

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The Pygmalion Effect & Growth Mindset

The Concept

The Pygmalion Effect dictates that our expectations of others shape their actual outcomes. If we assume an employee cannot change, they won't.

Application

Approaching the difficult conversation with a Growth Mindset means focusing on how you can help them improve their performance, rather than simply penalizing past mistakes.

ASK: “How can I help you improve your performance?”

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Step 1: The Clarity Checklist

Diagnostic Prep

- What is this person doing that they should not be doing?
- What is this person not doing that they should be doing?

Energy Prep

- ✗ Bring negative energy into the room.
- ✓ Clean up negative energy (as much as possible).
- ✓ Assume positive intent.
- ✓ Identify what they are doing right.
- ✓ Identify what you like about this person.

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The Pre-Meeting Ritual: The Letter

1. **Write.** Before the meeting, write a letter to your employee.
2. **Acknowledge.** List all their great qualities, what you appreciate about them, and why you believe in them.
3. **Commit.** Print the letter and bring it to the meeting.

This is not an easy task, but it is a life-changing one. It forces the manager into a space of mutual respect and joining, completely eliminating the 'Fight' response.

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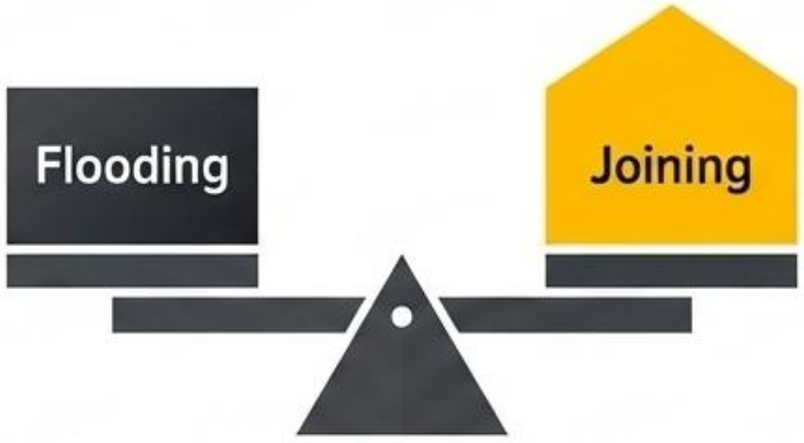
Entering the Room: Joining vs. Flooding



Rule 1: Move towards the conflict (Joining).
Use empathy, focus on the big picture, and utilize small, validating gestures.

Rule 2: Pretend you know nothing.
Even if you know the facts, assume you don't. Ask and listen first. Let them map the territory.

Rule 3: Keep quiet.
Allow silence to do the heavy lifting.

Source - Adar Cohen Ted Talk

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Best Practices for the Dialogue

Good feedback is a two-way conversation. (Reference: Joe Hirsch, Harvard Business Review)

The Empathy Engine

DO ↗

- Be specific.
- Be empathic.
- Make it a true dialogue.
- Focus on performance, not personality.
- Follow-up.

DON'T ⊗

- Don't wait for the annual/quarterly review.
- Don't use the "sandwich approach" (hiding the critique between fake compliments).

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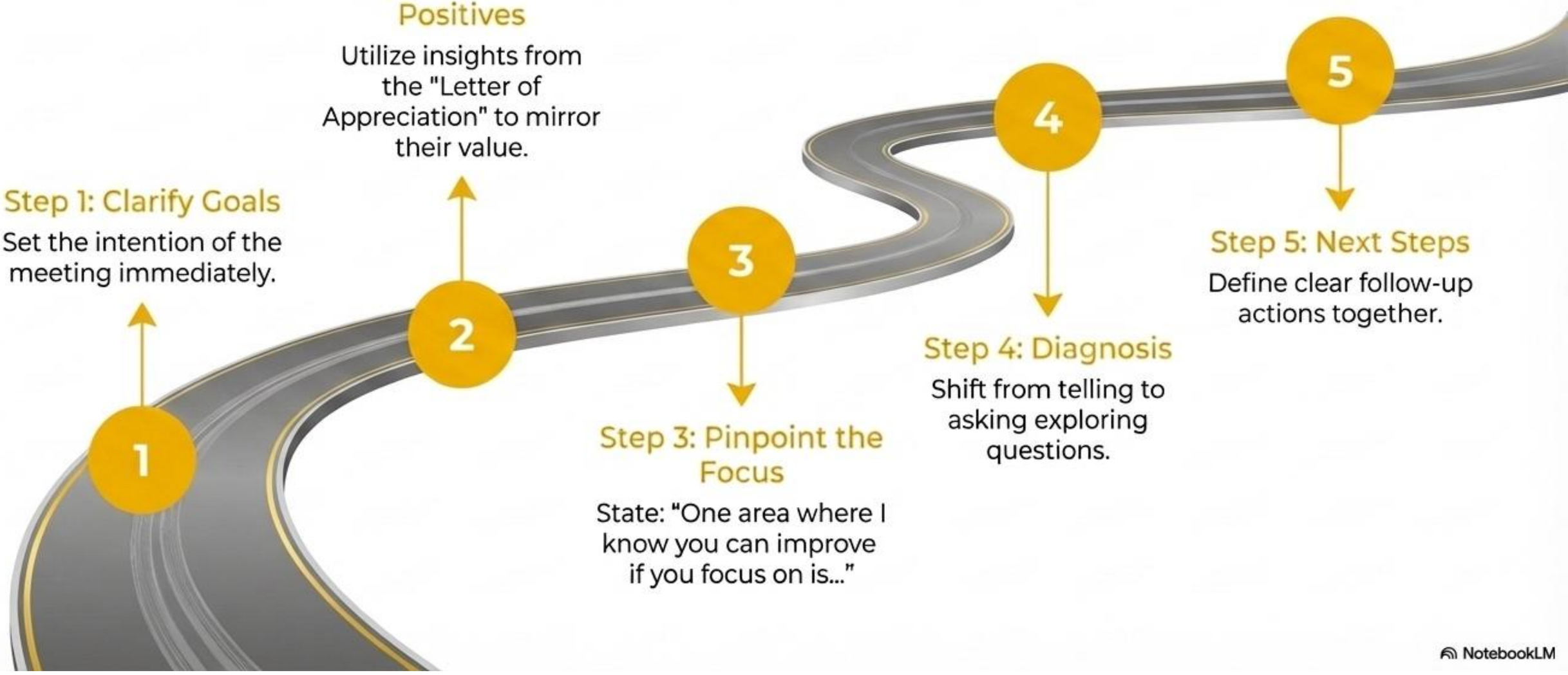
The Conversation Blueprint



Step 1: Clarify Goals

Set the intention of the meeting immediately.

Step 2: Start with Positives

Utilize insights from the "Letter of Appreciation" to mirror their value.

Step 3: Pinpoint the Focus

State: "One area where I know you can improve if you focus on is..."

Step 4: Diagnosis

Shift from telling to asking exploring questions.

Step 5: Next Steps

Define clear follow-up actions together.

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Diagnostic Questioning

When tension rises, shift from making statements to asking diagnostic questions.

What outcome are you trying to achieve?	What is happening from your perspective?	Why do you think it's happening?
What have you tried so far?	How have you handled similar challenges in the past?	What happened as a result of those attempts?

Anticipating Resistance

Emotional reactions to change are inevitable. When an employee pushes back, it triggers the manager's "Fight or Flight" response.

Contrary to popular thought, resistance is not bad. It is a sign of engagement. A lack of resistance usually signifies a lack of trust or a "Freeze" response.

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The Hidden Benefits of Resistance

1 Benefit 1: Fine-Tuning

Encourages management to adapt and improve the change plan based on ground-level realities.

2 Benefit 2: Uncovering Blindspots

Identifies specific areas of uniqueness or challenges in different organizational units that the manager missed.

3 Benefit 3: Forcing Dialogue

Encourages a better, deeper communication process between management and employees, breaking superficial agreement.

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In-The-Moment Tactics

1. Listen & Reflect

Show genuine interest. Repeat in your own words what you heard, rephrase.

2. The Salami Principle

Slice it thin. Don't try to resolve the entire conflict at once. Agree on one small, acceptable slice of progress.

3

Breathe and explicitly slow the pace of the conversation down.

4. Find Alternative Paths

Acknowledge that it might take more than one meeting to resolve. Remove the pressure to fix it instantly.

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Hug the Resistance

Know your own physiological reaction to pushback. When your instinct tells you to fight or flee the elephant in the room—embrace it instead. Accept the resistance as a massive, valid presence,

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The Path Forward

Mindset

Conflict is not a threat; it is the necessary friction for growth and trust.

Preparation

Assume positive intent, mirror their value, and write the letter of appreciation.

Execution

Move toward the conflict. Join instead of flooding. Ask diagnostic questions.

Resistance

Do not fight pushback. Hug the resistance and use it to fine-tune the outcome.

Difficult conversations are the crucible where mutual trust and respect are built.

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